Social Structure- Social status and Role

Learning Objectives

- Define the concepts of social structure, status and role
- Identify different classifications of social status and social roles
- Explain the relationship between status and role

Learning outcomes

- Explain the concept of social structure, status and role
- Describe different types of social status and role
- Evaluate the significance or interrelationship between status and role in social structure

Introduction

Social structure is a system of interconnected relationships, institutions, and roles. Together, they form the framework of a society. It explains the relationships between individuals and groups and how society is structured on the basis of shared rules, norms, and values. Simply put, social structure is the core of social life that provides order and stability to human interactions.

Society is a group of people who live in a particular area, interact with each other regularly, and share the same culture. In every society, there are some large or macro institutions that directly or indirectly influence the social structure. These are mainly the family, economy, education, politics, and religion. Institutions are the sources or main subjects for organizing the various activities, relationships, and roles that exist in society.

Along with institutions, the rules and norms that govern people's daily behaviour are essential components of social structure. These norms help regulate social life by making social interactions predictable and orderly.

Social structure affects:

- The functioning of institutions and their interaction with one another.
- The values, goals, and expectations of social life.
- The behaviour and choices of individuals and groups.

Every person has a certain position and role in the social structure. When individuals perform these roles as expected, social life becomes organized and unpredictable. Social identities are often recognized and evaluated by others based on the positions one holds and the roles one plays. Furthermore, these positions can determine people's social and economic prospects, behaviour, and even self-concept. In other words, social structure not only maintains society as a stable system, but also serves as an indispensable link between the individual and the social order.

Origin of the Concept: Social Structure

The word "structure" is taken from the English word "structure", which literally means "building construction" or "manner of organisation" or “arrangement of body parts”. It is an indication of how different parts are arranged or put together to form a whole.

By the 16th century, the word structure had broadened its meaning and was used to describe the interrelationship of the parts of any complete system. It was used in many scientific fields, such as physics, chemistry, anatomy, and physiology, to demonstrate how the different parts of a system are related and coordinated.

The term "social structure" had particular relevance in social sciences such as sociology and social anthropology, because the central goal of these sciences is to understand and explain the patterns and relationships that exist among people living in human societies, that is, the interaction of individuals and groups in society leads to the emergence of a social system.

After 1850, the discussion of social structure in sociology was largely influenced by the ideas of Herbert Spencer. Spencer viewed society as a biological organism. Like an organism, society has different interconnected "parts" - such as the heart, limbs, and brain - each part performing its own specific function to maintain the whole body; similarly, the interdependent parts of society are the family, religion, economy, government, etc. Each of these social institutions performs some function that contributes to the survival and functioning of society as a whole.

Among sociologists and anthropologists, scholars such as Émile Durkheim, Karl Marx, and Lewis H. Morgan used the concept of structure in various ways. They argued that societies are made up of structurally related elements and that in doing so they preserve a quality of order and stability. In fact, while modern sociologists do not fully agree with Spencer's analogy to the biological model (i.e., comparing society to an organism), they still adhere to the core idea that society represents a system of interconnected parts with its own structure and function.

Most of the ideas about social structure in the 20th century were refined, and promoted by:

- Radcliffe-Brown and his followers in Britain
- George P. Murdock in America
- Claude Lévi-Strauss in France

The above-mentioned scholars have used this concept extensively in their research on social systems and cultural patterns. Currently, the term social structure can be defined as "the orderly, patterned relationships that exist between the elements of a society." From a natural science concept, the concept of social structure has become one of the key concepts in sociology that has helped to understand how societies function and how they exist.

Meaning: Social Structure

When we say "structure," we mean the orderly arrangement of parts or elements that together form a whole. Everything that exists has a structure - an atom, a movie, a novel, a city, a tree, or even a person. What these examples have in common is that they are all made up of different parts that are organized and related to each other. For example, a building is made up of many

materials, such as stones, sand, bricks, cement, iron, and glass. Only when these parts are put together in an orderly and meaningful way do they become a proper building. Similarly, society also has a structure called social structure.

The elements or units of social structure are people. One of the characteristics of social structure noted by anthropologist A. R. Radcliffe-Brown is that it "refers to the network of relationships that actually exist between people." He also noted that "social structures are as real as individual organisms."

Just as the physical and mental processes of an organism depend on the anatomical structure of the body (composed of cells and fluids), the social behaviour of humans depends on the social structure that binds them together.

A person is not only a biological being, but also an individual who occupies a place in society and is engaged in social duties. Humans are eternally social; they cannot live alone. In order to exist and develop, people create groups and societies, which then become cultured to satisfy their common needs - biological, economic, social, psychological.

The basic needs mentioned above led to the emergence of universal social structures such as the family, economic systems, and political institutions, which, first of all, perform essential functions in society.

In fact, individuals in a society are the remnants of life, and they will inevitably be changed by birth, death, or movement; however, the social structure remains. This is similar to the way a human body maintains its structure even though the actual molecules are constantly being replaced. What remains unchanged is the arrangement or pattern that gives the structure its form and function.
Therefore, sociologists agree that any society, whether it is a primitive society or a highly developed one, has certain basic structures or groups, such as family, kinship, religion, economy, and government, which exist in all cultures.

Definitions of Social Structure
The concept of social structure has been defined in different ways by different thinkers. Let us consider some of these definitions.

- Radcliffe Brown:- Social structure as "an arrangement of persons in institutionally controlled or defined relationships, (such as the relationship of King and subject, or that of husband and wife)"

- Morris Ginsberg:- Social stricture as "the complex of principal groups and institutions which constitute societies"

<u>Elements of Social Structure</u>

Sociologist H.M. Johnson suggested that there are important elements in social structure. These elements give us a clear picture of how social order is established and how people relate to each other in it.

1. Sub-Groups of Various Types

Society is a collective system of human individuals who live together and interact with each other. Within this larger group, there are many smaller groups or subgroups that perform certain functions of society.

The examples are as follows:

- Political groups- such as parties and administrative bodies
- Economic groups- like business firms and cooperatives
- Religious groups- such as temples, churches, or mosques
- Educational groups- such as schools, colleges, and universities
- Familial groups- like families and kinship networks

Every one of these sub-groups performs the different functions, follows the different norms, and has different roles. The people who work in these subgroups (for example, teachers in schools or priests in temples) are organized according to the needs and morals of the community. Some of these subgroups persist even when members change. For example, a school continues to exist even when teachers or students change. Social norms regulate and define the interactions and roles between members of each subgroup.

2. Roles of Various Types

A role is the expected behaviour associated with a particular position or status in society. Social structure includes not only groups but also the roles that people have within those groups.

For instance:

- The father, mother, and children in a family each have different roles and responsibilities.
- In a college, the teacher has duties toward the students, and the students have duties toward the teachers and the institution.

These roles are all dependent on each other and are governed by norms. For example, the economic, political, and educational institutions of society are interconnected through the common values and social expectations they hold. Therefore, roles and subgroups are interdependent, and when combined, they form the social structural framework.

3. Regulative Norms Governing Sub-Groups and Roles

Each sub-group and role are regulated by social norms that provide guidance on how individuals should behave in society.

These norms can be broadly classified into two major types:

1. Obligatory or Relational Norms:

These norms specify positive duties, that is, what one should do according to one's role. For example, the duties of a father are not the same as the duties of a son; the duties of a family are

different from the duties of a business entity. Such norms depend on the specific relationship between people or groups.

2. Permissive or Regulative Norms:

These norms specify what people are allowed to do or not to do – the boundaries of acceptable behaviour. For example, no one has the right to use threats or violence to coerce others, regardless of a person's role. These norms apply to every person in society, thus ensuring order and justice.

3. Cultural Values

Every society is built on a foundation of cultural values. Simply put, values are essential beliefs about what is good, right, and important for a society. People often have strong emotional attachments to these values.

Values serve two main functions. On the one hand, they define an individual's identity and serve as a guide to behaviour. On the other hand, they are a shared foundation that enables cooperation in society. In conflict situations, these common values can be used as a compass to accurately find solutions. However, conflicts do occur. This is because no society is fully integrated, and the values of its members may sometimes be in conflict.

Finally, it is important to note the relationship between values and norms. Try to understand values as general, guiding principles, and norms as specific, unwritten rules of behaviour. Since values are the main source of our rules of behaviour, they can be considered a "higher level" of norms.

Parts of Social Structure

According to the sociologist A. R. Radcliffe-Brown, the term "social structure" does not refer to just one thing. He argued that it consists of three main things:

- Relationships between people: This is the foundation of the social structure. It involves the direct, human-to-human, contact or communication, that occurs in society, for example between members of a family, friends, or workers.
- Social roles: These are the different roles or characters that members assume in society. For example, the roles of "student", "doctor" or "parent" all come with a set of expectations and behaviours.
- Social positions: This is about the status or rank of a person in the social system. It is related to people being placed in different categories or levels, thus forming a social hierarchy.

Radcliffe-Brown saw social structure as a network of relationships, roles, and privileges that ensure the functional cooperation of human life.

Social Structure:- Status and Role

An integral feature of social structure is that members of society are distinguished on the basis of the social positions to which they belong. Each individual has a specific position in society

and its different subgroups - such as the family, the workplace, or society. With these positions come specific rights and duties, which determine not only how individuals relate to each other, but also the social order they thus create.

A social position has, according to H. M. Johnson, two main components:

- Obligations - the expected from a person duties and responsibilities.
- Rights - the privileges and entitlements that go with a position.

Johnson put it that these two components constitute what he called the status-role entity, where:

- "Role" indicates the obligations that go with a position.
- "Status" indicates the rights connected to it.

Simply put, status reveals one's position in society, while role tells us what one will do from that position.

Status

Socially, the concept of status refers to the position of an individual in a society. Each society classifies its members according to status, e.g. teacher, student, doctor, shopkeeper, etc. Each status has its own power, prestige, and behavioural requirements.

When talking about status, sociologists refer to it as an analytical concept rather than a descriptive one. They do not focus on simple labels such as bus conductor or customer, but rather on the patterns of rights and respect associated with these positions.

The term gained particular importance after Ralph Linton pointed out that status and role are key features of structural-functional theory. Later, sociologists such as R.K. Merton and Talcott Parsons developed and broadened these concepts.

Meaning of Status

Status is the socially marked position of an individual in a society or a group. Examples of status include student, teacher, mother, father, child, and employee. A person can have several statuses at the same time, for example, a person can be a teacher, mother, and citizen at the same time.

A person who holds a particular status is expected to behave appropriately in different situations. For example, the relationship between a father and a child is two-way - both have different positions and expectations in the family.

Status is always a relative concept, that is, it is available only in relation to others. One cannot be a "teacher" without "students" or a "father" without a "child". With each status comes certain privileges, rights, and duties. For example:

- One of the rights given to a teacher is to guide students, and he/she is also given the obligation to teach sincerely.
- One of the rights given to a student is to learn, and he/she is also given the obligation to obey academic rules.

As a result of these expectations, social behaviour becomes predictable and organized.

In most contexts, the terms status and social status are used interchangeably. However, there is a slight difference between them. Status is a term that refers to a person's position within a group or social system, for example, a student, a teacher, or a parent. On the other hand, social status is about the prestige, dignity, and respect that others give to a person because of that position. It refers to a person's relative social standing in a hierarchy of social value. For example, a teacher and a student have positions within a school, but the teacher usually holds the higher social position because society associates the role of a teacher with greater power and respect.

Thus, social status expresses the position and status of a person in society or community. It is the social identity of that person and how others see it in terms of respect and importance. In fact, social status encompasses all the roles and positions that lead to one's overall status in society. Some social statuses are very broad, for example, those related to gender or age, while others are very specific, for example, occupational positions such as doctor, farmer, or engineer.

A person's social status depends on many factors, such as biological sex, age, race, caste, class, and economic status. In addition, physical appearance, intelligence, good character, and personal characteristics also affect how society views a person. For example, in traditional societies, older individuals receive higher social status because age is associated with wisdom and experience, while in modern societies, occupation and income are more considered when assigning status.

Definition of Status

- Ralph Linton:- “Status is the place in a particular system, which a certain individual occupies at a particular time.”
- Duncan Mitchell:- Social status refers to "the position occupied by a person, family, or kinship group in a social system relative to others. This determines rights, duties and other behaviours, including the nature and extent of the relationships with persons of other statuses"
- Morris Ginsberg:- “A status is a position in a social group or grouping, a relation to other positions held by other individuals in the group or grouping.”
- Kingsley Davis:- “status is a position in the general institutional system, recognized and supported by the entire society.”
- Horton and Hunt:- “status is the rank or position of an individual in a group.”
- Weber:- “Status refers to the esteem or ‘social honour’ given to individuals or groups”.

Nature of Status

One of the elements that helps us understand the social system is the concept of status, which is an important element of social structure. Status is not only the place where a person can be found within a group, but also the expectations, rights, and obligations that come with that place. Through these key points, the nature of status becomes clearer.

1. External symbols to identify status:

Usually, in a social context, a person's personality reveals their status. There are some external signs that greatly help in finding one's place in society. For example, uniform is one of the most visible and obvious indicators - the uniform of a soldier, police officer, doctor, nurse, lawyer or a priest is different and uniquely identifies a particular profession and role.

Another example of external identification can be the badges or symbols worn by police officers or military personnel, which reveal the rank and position of others. In some societies, married and unmarried people, young and old, or even professions such as merchants and tailors are distinguished by different types of clothing. However, such identification has its own disadvantages, as people may wear certain clothes for entertainment, fashion and strategy.

2. Every status has its own rights, duties, and obligations:

Each position held by an individual in a society is associated with specific rights, duties, and obligations. These rights and duties are shaped by the normative system of society. In this case, a right is a reasonable expectation that an individual in a particular position may have regarding the behaviour of others.

From another perspective, that expectation is an obligation. For example, an employer has the right to expect disciplined behaviour from employees, while employees have the obligation to fulfill that expectation. On the other hand, employees have the right to be paid for their work, and the employer has the obligation (or duty) to pay them wages. Therefore, rights and obligations are dual components of the same social relationship.

3. Social statuses are governed by norms:

Each social status is defined by certain norms, i.e. rules that indicate expected behaviour. However, these norms depend on individuals, situations, and roles. Although some norms, such as "to be honest" or "to be truthful," are said to be universal, their implementation can vary significantly.

For example, a doctor may decide not to tell a patient the whole truth about his illness in order not to upset the patient, while a merchant may sometimes change his honesty in order to maintain profit. Thus, norms always depend on the given situation and the relationship between the communication partners.

4. One individual may have several statuses:

Since a network of statuses is the way society works, each individual has multiple statuses. Highly complex societies have more different types of statuses. Nowadays, a person can be in many different roles in a single day. For example, a college student's relationships can be: with teachers - a student, with a shopkeeper - a customer, with his sister - a brother, with his parents - a son, with a doctor - a patient.

Therefore, an individual is a person who simultaneously holds several statuses, each of which carries certain rights and obligations. Members of simple societies may have only a few statuses, but members of complex, modern societies may have a much larger number of them due to social roles and human relationships.

The nature of status reflects the social framework and the way it functions. It gives individuals their distinctiveness, regulates them through a set of norms, and unites them with a network of rights and obligations.

5. Statuses influence individual careers:

A person's social and professional life is largely determined by the statuses he holds. A person's dreams and behaviour can only be truly understood if they are considered in relation to the status structures of society. For example, an Eskimo would never think of becoming a nuclear physicist, because such a profession does not exist in an Eskimo society. Therefore, the statuses of a society affect that person's career development and the first of their aspirations.

6. Statuses differ in importance:

A person's social position is not entirely determined by their status. Different societies attach varying degrees of importance to the same status. In most modern industrial societies, occupational status is the dominant status - it greatly influences other aspects of a person's life, such as social status, income, and lifestyle. In contrast, in traditional or non-industrial societies, kinship, religious, or political status may be more reliant on status. For example, caste and occupation are the two most influential factors in India. In early societies, factors such as age, gender, and kinship may have determined roles more significantly.

7. Statuses contribute to social order and stability:

Statuses are deeply intertwined with social structure, and they play a crucial role in maintaining social order and stability. A person comes into the world with a social structure that already has established statuses, such as farmers, teachers, soldiers, and clerks. These statuses are not newly created by new generations, but are inherited from existing social arrangements. Most people are in existing statuses, although occasionally some statuses may be formed through innovation or the unique achievements of individuals. Along with other cultural elements, statuses are fluid-some of them may become obsolete over time, while others may emerge, but the social status framework is essentially a vehicle for society to move forward and become what it is as a whole.

8. Social status is of hierarchical nature:

In every society, status is distributed hierarchically - no two social positions are of equal value. A very small number of individuals, that is, hold the highest or most prestigious positions, while the majority hold ordinary or lower ranks. Theoretically, this distribution should be based on merit and ability: those with more skills, abilities, or qualifications will receive higher status. However, in reality, factors such as heredity, property ownership, social background, and privilege affect a person's social status and ability. Therefore, the relationship between ability and higher status is not always very strong. Social hierarchies exist because different social and economic forces determine how status is distributed among the members of a society.

Characteristics

A person's "position" in society is not just a title. It also comes with a set of key characteristics that characterize its importance and function. The key characteristics of a title are as follows:

- It meets a societal need

A title is not something that comes into being suddenly. It is established because it is useful to society. For example, society creates the title "doctor" or "teacher" because healthcare and education need to function.

- It includes authority

A person's status is often associated with a degree of power. That is, the person holding that position (such as a manager or a police officer) has the ability to direct or influence the actions of others.

- It is relative

A status can only be understood in comparison to other statuses. The example of "manager" explains it best, that is, it is difficult to understand the concept of "manager" without the status of an "employee". In this way, the status of "parents" is considered in comparison to a "child".

- It shows social ranking

Status is an integral part of social stratification - the way society is divided into different classes or levels. Your status, in most cases, reveals your place on this social ladder.

- It comes with privileges

A person's status is usually associated with certain benefits or protections. For example, a CEO may have the privilege of a private office and a company car, while a diplomat may enjoy immunity from prosecution in a foreign country.

- It has prestige

More than anything else, each title has a certain amount of prestige, which is the amount of social respect or esteem it garners from others. For example, the title of a brain surgeon is usually associated with high prestige.

- It can include payment

Many positions, especially those in the professional field, come with the right to be paid for the work performed. Usually, this compensation is called remuneration.

- It is inseparable from role

The two concepts of status and role are closely related, in fact they are like two sides of the same coin. Simply put, status is the position you hold (e.g., "student"), while role is the set of behaviours and expectations associated with that position (e.g., attending lectures and studying). You have a status, but you perform a role.

Types of Status

Statuses are culturally recognized and socially held positions. While some may have a biological basis, such as gender, race, or age, their significance and value are derived from

cultural and social norms. Sociologist, Ralph Linton distinguished two main types of status: Ascribed and achieved status.

1. Ascribed Status:

Ascribed status is the social unit into which a person is born and which usually cannot be changed without considerable effort. It is an entity that is given at birth and remains more or less constant throughout life. Good examples are gender, caste, ethnicity, and age. These are roles over which a person cannot exercise power or make choices.

For example, a person born into a Brahmin family in India immediately receives the assigned status of Brahmin. Similarly, one's religion, nationality, and family background are all assigned statuses based on birth. There is the possibility of changing religion or caste later in life, but initially, these are assigned without one's choice.

2. Achieved Status:

Achieved status is a social position that a person achieves or chooses through their own efforts, abilities, or the results of that achievement. These positions are dependent on a person's actions and are inversely related to those positions. Examples include the role of a teacher, doctor, engineer, athlete, or parent.

When thinking about earned status, one thinks about the person's achievements and abilities, and what society recognizes and values. Thus, earned statuses are positions that are given and often permanent, while earned statuses are positions that are earned through one's own actions and can vary throughout a person's life. Together, the two types determine a person's place and identity in society.

There are a few different ways of status acquired a personal may achieve:

First

In the world's view, only people with extraordinary and great abilities can hold certain positions. To be clear, becoming a world-class artist, scientist, or musician is not a matter of your own decision alone. These positions are inevitably acquired through the extraordinary nature of one's talent and the fervor of one's creation.

Second

Public recognition and acceptance can lead to another type of status. Celebrities such as athletes, singers, and actors who rise to the top in any field become highly regarded individuals, regardless of where they come from. Their social status is measured by their performances and the recognition they receive from others.

Third

Most professional positions are the result of hard and long training. So, to become a doctor, lawyer, or engineer, one must study for many years and work hard at the same time. In short, these are not positions you can be born into; rather, they are the result of personal effort and qualification.

An Achieved Status in Modern Society

Most statuses in modern society are achieved ones that include:

- ☺ Occupational Status: Most jobs and careers are a matter of one's skills and qualifications.
- ☺ Group Membership: A professional organization, sports team, or a club are examples of an achieved status because they depend on your actions and not someone else's.
- ☺ Family and Personal Status: Such social roles as "husband," "wife," "parent," or even "university graduate" are achieved statuses because they are the outcomes of personal choices and effort.

Emphasizing the status achieved in a social system means that the situation is dynamic and people automatically cooperate in it. As individuals acquire different sociocultural roles due to personal efforts, they acquire expertise and thereby become interdependent, so that we as a society function smoothly. Thus, not only healthy competition (when people strive to achieve their goals) but also cooperation (when they work together) is encouraged, the end result of which is a more progressive and adaptable society.

Interrelationship between Ascribed and Achieved status

We acquire a social status in the early days of our lives. Our initial social status is very important because it is through it that we first learn the culture and rules of our society. As we grow up, we begin to acquire statuses that are earned through our actions. However, most often, our attribute status, which is the attribute status we are born with, influences the opportunities we receive later.

Both types of status are essential for a society to function properly. A society based solely on status will be very unstable. People will constantly fight for positions, creating a climate of insecurity, while some essential but unattractive jobs will remain unfilled. A society based solely on attributed status will have the advantage of having a very stable house of cards, because the life path of the individual will be predetermined from birth, so that none of them will be tempted to work hard or be creative. Thus, ascribed status provides stability, while achieved status is a source of inspiration and progress.

How They Work Together in Different Societies?

These two types of status overlap in real life. To illustrate this point, consider a person who is simultaneously a man (the ascribed status) and a doctor (the achieved status). In some traditional cultures, a person's ascribed status may limit the number of roles a person can take on, reducing the pressure to choose. At the same time, the status they have achieved is a reflection of their personal achievements.

The relationship between ascribed and achieved status varies in different societies:

- ❑ Traditional or rigid societies rely heavily on ascribed status. Your position is largely determined by your birth.

- Modern, democratic, and industrial societies typically focus more on achieved status. In these societies, social mobility is highly valued, and therefore, one can improve their position through hard work and ability.

Both types of status are necessary. Ascribed status ensures social order and continuity, while achieved status is a source of change, creativity, and personal development. Together, they form a stable but flexible social structure.

ROLE

Roles in society or larger social structures are concepts based on behaviour and social patterns. They identify the behaviour of an individual within the categories, structures, or social status of society that an individual occupies. A role is generally accepted as a set of behaviours that are maintained by a particular individual through the operation of the same social structure. The word is taken from the theatre field, which clearly shows the actor (individual) and the role. Society has social roles for individuals, as an actor has his character on stage. Since different individuals may be able to replace the same position over time, such a role is a stable one. In other words, it is generally accepted that anyone who takes on the role of teacher or doctor is expected to meet the standards and expectations set for that position.

Roles, which provide norms of behaviour, enable people to act correctly and interact with others in different contexts, for example, with those who perform their roles, such as parent-child or teacher-student relationships. Each individual may have a personality that distinguishes them from others, however, when brought together, a set of socially acceptable behaviours becomes a conceptual group of society.

Role expectations include the actions and behaviours that are performed. For example, a teacher should not only explain lessons, assign homework, and conduct exams, but also be a role model of honesty, responsibility, dedication, and care for students. Similarly, a doctor is expected to demonstrate competence, care, and ethical integrity in addition to his or her professional duties.

Furthermore, a person is essentially a combination of multiple roles, such as parent, spouse, employee, citizen, or friend. These roles are equipped with different types of rights, duties, privileges, and obligations, which sometimes support each other and sometimes create conflicts between roles when the expectations of one role interfere with the expectations of another. Therefore, realizing the concept of roles is the first step in sociology, because roles are the foundation of predictable social behaviour, cooperation between people, and social order.

Definition of Role

- Ogburn and Nimkoff:- A role is “a set of socially expected and approved behaviour patterns consisting of both duties and privileges, associated with a particular position in a group.”
- Johnson:- “Role is expectations and obligations held by other members concerning the behaviour of the position incumbent.”

- ❖ Alex Inkles:- ‘Role’ refers to “the set of expected or normative rights and obligations allowed to and demanded of persons generally felt to be incumbent of a recognized status by others who participate in the same social system.”
- ❖ Young and Mack:- "A role is the function of a status.”
- ❖ Robert Bierstedt:- A "role is the dynamic or the behavioural aspect of status. A role is what an individual does in the status he occupies.”

Nature of Role

Social roles are a set of behaviours that individuals engage in in society, and these behaviours are expected from their different statuses. The study of different social roles reveals their defining characteristics:

- ⌘ Role-playing is compulsory for all members of society:

Any person who belongs to a society or community is expected to play certain roles. Being part of social life means playing roles. The number and type of roles a person plays depends on how many positions that person holds. For example, a person can be a teacher, a parent, a friend, and a citizen at the same time.

- ⌘ Some roles are common to many individuals:

There are certain social roles that are widely known and performed by many people. Examples include roles such as adult, citizen, voter, student, teacher, or minister. These roles exist to a large extent and are fundamental to the normal flow of society.

- ⌘ Some roles are limited only to a few individuals:

There are also positions that only a very few people can hold at any given time. For example, in India, the number of governors or chief ministers at a time is equal to the number of states, because each state can only have one governor or chief minister. These positions are different, and only a limited number of people can hold them.

- ⌘ Some roles are voluntarily assumed:

Some roles are chosen by an individual, not taken on out of necessity. A person may choose to live in a city and become a city dweller, may decide to join a cricket team and take on the role of a bowler, or may decide to join a voluntary organisation and become an executive member. Such roles are chosen by an individual and reflect his personal goals or interests.

In short, social roles represent the core elements of the social system. They describe the behaviour expected of people in different situations, thus making social life more predictable, coordinated, and orderly.

Key Characteristics of a Social Role

The term "social role" is not a simple concept; it has many characteristics that explain how it functions in social life.

- ✡ Role is the 'Action' part of a status

If you think of a position as your position (e.g., "student" or "doctor"), then what you do in that position (e.g., attending lectures or treating patients) is a role. A role is the active, behavioural role that comes from the position.

- A role cannot exist without a status

Roles are always associated with a specific position. You can't "drive the bus" without being a "bus driver." They are two sides of the same coin; one refers to the position, the other to the expected actions.

- Roles are shaped by culture

This role is not an independent role; it is determined by the culture of the society. Culture acts like a "script" for a role, dictating how it should be performed.

- Culture provides the rules for a role

The "Normative aspect" is closely related to the point mentioned above. It refers to the set of rules and expectations that govern the behaviour of individuals. Culture tells us what is considered normal or appropriate for a particular role.

- A role is always relative to other roles

The existence of a role depends on its relationship to other roles. For example, the role of a "teacher" gets its meaning only in relation to the role of a "student". Similarly, the role of a "doctor" is explained by its relationship to the role of a "patient". They do not exist independently, but in pairs or groups.

Classification of Roles

Social roles can be classified in different ways depending on their nature, degree of interdependence, and relationship to other roles. The two most important classifications are relational and non-relational roles, and basic, general, and independent roles.

1. Relational and Non-relational Roles

Some roles in a society are conceptually constructed from others, and are therefore related in nature. These are called kinship roles. As an example, the role of wife is not possible without the role of husband, and similarly, the role of debtor is not possible without the debtor. Such roles are interdependent, and their definition can only be obtained when they are considered together. Similarly, most kinship roles, for example, father-son, brother-sister, or teacher-student, are kinship roles because they depend on the existence of related roles.

In contrast, Non-relational roles do not rely on or complement other roles. They are self-contained and are explained by the actions or activities of a person. The roles of a musician, researcher, or painter are some examples. Typically, roles that are age and gender-specific are considered unrelated, while kinship roles are primarily kinship roles.

2. Basic, General, and Independent Roles

Sociologist Banton proposed a criterion for comparing the degree to which certain roles depend on other roles. He divided them into three types:

a) Basic Roles:

Those roles are determined primarily by gender and age, and are assigned to individuals at birth. Basic roles significantly influence a person's behaviour in different social situations. For example, the roles of a man, a woman, a child, or an adult fall into this category.

b) General Roles

Typically, roles in this context are acquired and assigned based on a person's qualifications or abilities. They are not limited in their scope and affect social interaction in a variety of situations. Examples include teacher, doctor, or leader roles.

c) Independent Roles:

Such roles are largely the result of personal achievement or decision, and are not dependent on other roles. They do not significantly determine how others treat the person who occupies them. Examples include leisure roles (such as a traveller or a hobbyist) and mostly professional roles (such as a freelance artist or an independent researcher).

Dimensions of Roles

Social roles are not only abstract but also complex, as they encompass various aspects that govern individual behaviour and social interaction. According to sociologists, roles have four main dimensions, namely, multiple roles and roles, role marking, role transition, and role conflict and stress. These aspects of roles enable us to see how people act in their social environments and how they manage their duties and expected behaviours.

1. Multiple Roles and Role Set

Sociologist Robert K. Merton (1957) emphasized the fundamental distinction between multiple roles and a role set. Previously, Ralph Linton had argued that each status had a role. However, Merton argued that each status was actually a set of distinct but related roles, which he called a role set.

Role Set → different roles linked to one status.

Multiple Roles → different roles linked to multiple statuses of one person.

A role set is a term that refers to the network of relationships and expectations that accompany a particular position. For example, a medical student's position involves interactions not only with teachers, but also with nurses, doctors, patients, and social workers. The relationships with these people represent different elements of the role assigned to that position.

In contrast, multiple roles are the different roles that an individual performs as a result of holding multiple positions. For example, an individual can be a teacher, a parent, a citizen, a friend, and at the same time a person.

2. Role Signs

Role signs refer to outwardly visible signs that indicate a person's role in society. Often these are signs from the outside world, such as clothing, titles, uniforms, badges, or a particular gesture. For example, a doctor's white coat, a policeman's uniform, and a judge's robe are all signs that point to their roles.

Role signs facilitate communication and social control. They help others see a person's role, anticipate their behaviour, and respond to it. Role signs help the person behave correctly according to the expectations of their role, thus reducing situations of misunderstanding and possible role deviation.

As an example, the difference between the dress of men and women in different societies indicates different social expectations that arise from gender roles.

3. Role Changing

Roles are not socially determined; they change gradually and developmentally. People regularly change their roles from one to another as they go through different life stages or attain a particular social status. For example, a person may change from a student to a teacher, or from single to married.

When a person changes roles, it is necessary for the person and the people around them to change their behaviour and expectations. This adjustment maintains social cohesion. Role changes are usually accompanied by certain ceremonies or rituals, such as coming-of-age celebrations, graduation ceremonies, or weddings, which stand for social role changes. The transition from childhood to adulthood is one of the most important role changes in any society.

4. Role Conflict and Role Strain

Role conflict and role strain are difficulties associated with fulfilling one's social roles.

- Role conflict: Role conflict occurs when an individual faces the conflicting demands of two or more different roles. For example, a working parent may be conflicted between work and family responsibilities. The demands of each role may clash, creating stress and tension.
- Role strain: Role strain is a situation that occurs in a role when an individual finds it difficult to meet its differing expectations. For example, a teacher may struggle to balance classroom teaching, student counselling, and administrative work.

Role conflict and role strain refer to the pressures individuals face in trying to manage multiple social expectations. Proper role management means being able to find balance, prioritize tasks, and sometimes redefine expectations.

Interrelationships between social status and role

The concepts of status and role are very important concepts in social research because they create the framework of society and social interaction. An example of their relationship is given by sociologist Ralph Linton with the phrase "You hold a status, but you also play a role." The statement suggests that a person's status refers to his or her position in society, and a role refers

to the behaviour expected of that position. If you think about it, both status and role are the same thing- one cannot exist without the other.

Every human society is made up of people who are teachers, students, parents, and citizens at different times in their lives, and each of these positions entails a set of duties, rights, and behaviours known as roles. In this way, society places humans in different positions that legally determine their actions, and through these roles, in their socialization, they consolidate their status and relationships with the group. Sometimes, these positions (such as gender or caste) are given, and sometimes, they are acquired (such as a profession). Therefore, status and role are intertwined, with deep connections.

1. Status and Role are interrelated

Status is the position of a person in a society, and a role is the behaviour expected of that person. Take a teacher as an example (status), and we can say that the teacher is expected to teach, guide, and evaluate students' progress (roles). Therefore, people have statuses, but groups have roles. People fulfill the requirements of their statuses and, with them, their rights (roles) through the performance of roles.

2. Role is a relational term

A role is always defined in relation to others. It exists only through interaction between people who occupy corresponding positions, often called counter-roles. For instance, the role of a teacher exists in relation to the role of a student, and the role of a doctor is meaningful only in relation to the patient. This makes the concept of role highly relational, since it describes the way individuals behave toward others within a specific social context.

It is important to note that individuals-not organizations or institutions-actually play roles and occupy statuses during interactions in everyday life.

3. Status and role reflect different perspectives

Status is a concept that belongs to sociology, where it represents an individual's structural position in society. Role, on the other hand, is more closely related to social psychology, as it deals with behaviour, personality, and interaction. Status is a normative concept, so it is relatively stable, although individuals as members of a society differ in their personal qualities, upbringing, and social environment, and therefore in different manifestations of the same social role. For example, two teachers with the same status may differ in the ways they teach students and the ways they treat learners based on their personal qualities.

4. Both are dynamic

Attributes, status, and role are non-static-they are subject to change over time, adapting to social and individual practices. Whenever a new person assumes a particular position, the role changes as the new person applies his or her own personality, experience, and understanding. Similarly, a status can change if society changes the norms, expectations, or demands associated with it.

For example, as organizations develop or societies become more advanced, the terms of positions (e.g., teachers, leaders, or officeholders) may broaden or change. For example, the status of a teacher is not only a transmitter of knowledge but also a facilitator, counsellor, and technology user-roles that were not previously recognized.

Thus, status and role change over time, just like society, and are inherently dynamic entities. However, it should be emphasized that statuses are cultural because they are deeply tied to social structure and values, while roles are behavioural because they depend heavily on the performances of actual individuals.

5. Both are Correlative

There is a deep connection between status and role, they are mutually dependent and mutually supportive. At the same time, one can also find conceptual differences. A status without a role is equivalent to a position waiting for its owner, whether in society or in an institution. For example, a position that has been created but has not yet been filled. On the other hand, a person can assume a specific role without ever having a formally recognized status, for example when a person acts in a completely informal way as a leader or advisor to a community. This suggests that they are interconnected by giving meaning to each other, however, sociological research can still consider them as separate entities.

6. Status as an Institutionalized Role

The core of every social system is the statuses that form the framework, while roles characterize the functioning of that framework. Society is made up of institutionalized statuses, that is, they are formalized by norms and regulated by norms. These are social units that, in relation to norms and values, establish order, predictability, and stability in social relations. For example, social agencies such as the teacher, doctor, parent, and police officer perform functions of social organization and are important stabilizers of the social network. Each of these statuses is associated with certain roles that serve as mechanisms for social action and cooperation.

Conclusion

Primarily, the concepts of status and role are interrelated and are fundamental to social life. With changes in social norms, institutional structures, and individual behaviours, the relationship between status and role also changes. Both are important topics for understanding how individuals and groups function in society. On the one hand, status determines a person's position, and on the other hand, role is the expected behaviour that comes with that position.

- A status is a certain position in society or a group, whereas a role is the behaviour that corresponds to that position.
- People have different statuses, and they have different roles too-statuses give a person an identity, and roles give a function.

To fully define a status is to provide a description of the full range of roles expected of it. Therefore, it is important to know both concepts when social structure, human interaction, and institutional organization are topics of discussion in society.

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Check Your Progress

MCQ

1. …… is a system of interconnected relationships, institutions and roles

A) Ascribed status B) Socialization

C) Social structure D) None of the above

2. Which of the following sociologist consider society as a biological organism?

A) Herbert Spencer B) Merton

C) Karl Marx D) Radcliffe Brown

3. Who defined "Social structure as the complex of principal groups and institutions which constitute society"

A) Karl Marx B) Morris Ginsberg

C) Emile Durkheim D) Radcliffe Brown

4. According to Radcliffe Brown, which of the following is not a part of social structure?

A) Relationship between people B) Social roles

C) Social Positions D) Cultural values

5. Status refers to …….

A) Obligation of an individual B) Temporary role of an person
C) Position of an Individual D) Affective action

6. Which of the following is an example of an ascribed status?

A) Daughter B) Doctor

C) Teacher D) Student

7. Status acquired by person through birth, it is known as ……

A) Achieved status B) Ascribed status

C) No relational status D) Role

8. The person achieve a status through their own efforts and abilities, this types of status is known as ……..

A) Affective status B) Ascribed status

C) Affinal status D) Achieved status

9. The term role can defined as …….?

A) Expected behaviour associated with a status

B) Persons social conditions

C) Individual financial conditions

D) All of the above

10. Which of the following is not a type of role proposed by Banton?

A) Basic role B) General role

C) Non-relational role D) Independent role

11. The network of relationship and expectations that accompanying a particular positions, it is termed as ……..?

A) Multiple role B) Role set

C) Role signs D) None of the above

12. When a person experiences difficulty in fulfilling the expectations of a single role, it is called …….?

A) Role conflict B) Role sign

C) Role strain D) Role playing

13. The individual holding two or more conflicting roles at the same time, it is known as …….?

A) Master role B) Role conflict

C) Achieved role D) Role constrain

Short note

1. Define social structure
2. What you mean by status?
3. Define the concept of 'role'
4. Define ascribed and achieved status with examples
5. Differentiate between multiple role and role set?

Short essay

1. Discuss the concept of role conflict and role strain in everyday life
2. Briefly discuss the major classification of role
3. 'Status and Role' have any importance in the social structure". Substantiate.

Essay

1. Define the concept of social structure and discuss how status and role form its fundamental component?

MCQ Answers

1. C) Social structure
2. A) Herbert Spencer
3. B) Morris Ginsberg
4. D) Cultural values
5. C) Position of an Individual
6. A) Daughter
7. B) Ascribed status
8. D) Achieved status
9. A) Expected behaviour associated with a status
10. C) Non-relational role
11. B) Role set
12. C) Role strain
13. B) Role conflict

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